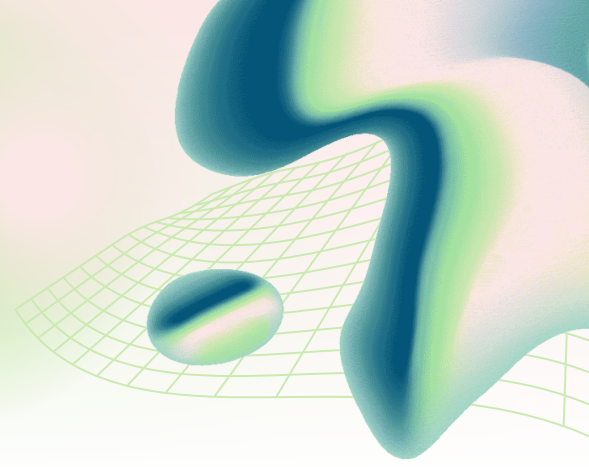


TRUSTED ADULT NETWORK

Building your support system.



A trusted adult network is a group of reliable adults in your life who you can turn to for advice, support, and guidance. These individuals can offer a different perspective, share their experiences, and help you navigate challenges. Building and nurturing these relationships is crucial for your personal growth and well-being.

Who Can Be a Trusted Adult?

Trusted adults come from various aspects of your life. Consider:

- **Family Members:** Parents, guardians, aunts, uncles, grandparents, older siblings.
- **Educators:** Teachers, counselors, coaches, librarians, mentors.
- **Community Leaders:** Religious leaders, youth group leaders, neighbors you know well.
- **Friends' Parents:** Adults you know through your friends who have shown themselves to be supportive.
- **Professionals:** Doctors, therapists, social workers, or other professionals you have a positive relationship with.

Qualities of a Trusted Adult

- **Good Listener:** They pay attention without judgment and try to understand your perspective.
- **Respectful:** They value your thoughts and feelings, even if they don't always agree.
- **Supportive:** They encourage you and offer help when you need it.
- **Reliable:** You can count on them to be there for you.
- **Honest:** They offer genuine advice, even if it's difficult to hear.
- **Problem-Solver:** They can help you think through issues and find solutions.
- **Confidential (within limits):** They will keep your conversations private, unless there is a concern for your safety or the safety of others.
- **Positive Role Model:** They demonstrate healthy behaviors and coping strategies.
- **Approachable:** You feel comfortable talking to them.

Why is a Trusted Adult Network Important?

Having a network of trusted adults provides a safety net. They can offer guidance during difficult times, celebrate your successes, and help you develop important life skills. Knowing you have people who care about you and want the best for you can significantly boost your confidence and resilience.

Activity: Map Your Network

Take some time to identify the trusted adults currently in your life and brainstorm potential additions.

1. **List Your Current Network:** On a piece of paper or digitally, write down the names of adults you already feel you can trust. Next to each name, briefly note why you trust them (e.g., "always listens," "gives good advice about school").
2. **Identify Gaps:** Are there areas where you feel you could benefit from more support? For example, do you need someone to talk to about career choices, hobbies, or specific challenges?
3. **Brainstorm New Connections:** Think about people in your life who might fit the qualities of a trusted adult. This could be a teacher you admire, a coach, a family friend, or a leader in an organization you're part of.
4. **Plan to Connect:** If you identify someone new, think about how you can start building that relationship. This might involve asking them for advice on a small matter, joining a club they lead, or simply making an effort to chat more often.
5. **Nurture Your Network:** Regularly check in with your trusted adults. Share updates, ask for their thoughts, and show your appreciation for their support.

Remember, building and maintaining a trusted adult network is an ongoing process. Investing time and effort in these relationships will pay dividends throughout your life.